Barakzai began to say publicly, “Shah Shuja is an English-lover. Don’t be misled by his words, which contradict his deeds. If this is not true, why hasn’t he started for Jalalabad and why haven’t the English left yet, in conformity with the documents he sent them?”’[54] As March progressed, and stories of Akbar’s bravery in Jalalabad began to circulate in Kabul, more and more of Shuja’s supporters, including his principal ally and Naib, Aminullah Khan Logari, urged him to show his commitment to the cause by marching immediately on Jalalabad, or at the very least to send one of his sons in his place.[55]

Placed in an impossible dilemma, and not wishing to give the British reasons to distrust him, Shuja bribed several of the chiefs to go ahead without him. On 2 March, Prince Timur was ordered off to Jalalabad, but never got any further than Butkhak at the mouth of the Khord Kabul.[56] On the 18th, Aminullah Khan and the Barakzais came to the Bala Hisar and at durbar publicly called upon the Shah to come out of his fortress and lead 8,000 men to join Akbar Khan in his fight against the infidels.[57] Maulana Hamid Kashmiri has the Barakzais compare Shuja’s duplicitous diplomacy to Akbar Khan’s fearless waging of war:

> One day, a group of chiefs and generals
> Gained access to the Shah’s audience chamber
>
> They said to him: ‘O Renowned Padshah!
> What will you do? Tell us!
>
> You hold your position of royal command
> Because we are firm in our pledge of service
>
> We believed you would defend the country
> That you would command and protect the rule of law
>
> So tell us what grievous wrong has Akbar committed?
> That you have girded your loins for his destruction?
>
> Except that he made you King in this land
> And rendered the forces of evil crippled and helpless
>
> Instead of raising him high
> You seek to throw him low
>
> You have delegated the task of killing him
> To certain men and faithless vermin